Mohammad had been sprung from his Bukhara dungeon. ‘The English in Kabul were resting in the arms of pleasure and sloth’, wrote Mirza ‘Ata, ‘when the news arrived that Amir Dost Mohammad Khan had escaped from Bukhara, helped by a private merchant who had bribed the watch appointed to guard the Amir – the sum was said to be some 10,000 Rupees’.

Reports began to arrive that the Amir had returned to northern Afghanistan and raised the flag of holy war. In late August the troops of the small British outpost at Saighan on the frontier of the territory of the Mir Wali of Kunduz, where the valley drops to the northern plains, were forced to fall back twenty miles to a more defensible position in Bamiyan. Worse still, a contingent of Shah Shuja’s troops sent to attack the Amir mutinied and joined the rebellion. Around the same time, news came that a quite separate rebellion had broken out in Kohistan only a few hours’ journey north of Kabul, where the Tajiks felt that the Shah had failed to reward them properly for their help in taking Kabul in 1839 and had betrayed all the promises that had been made to them.[w]

It had taken just a year for the Afghans to rise in revolution. But the jihad against the British had now begun.

It is the epic poets who give the fullest account of the Amir’s escape from Bukhara. Maulana Hamid Kashmiri tells of how a celebrated Kabul merchant, Khan Kabir, arrived in Bukhara with his caravan and heard that the Amir had been thrown into a pit. Grateful to Dost Mohammad for favours when he was in power,

> He put his heart and soul into achieving the Amir’s release
> Night and day he searched for a way out
> For the Amir’s assistance, he opened the hand of generosity
> And scattered gold so that the Amir’s jailer became his prisoner
>
> So bound was the warder by the Amir’s noose
> He endeavoured to serve him like a slave bought with gold
>
> When the Amir knew that the gate was open
> He found an opportunity one night, and hastened to escape[86]

Akbar Khan, who escaped at the same time, was quickly recaptured before he had managed to leave the city, but his father succeeded in getting away.